Dr Haithem Afli

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Current appointments and research leadership

• Lecturer in Artificial Intelligence, Munster Technological University
• Institutional Co-Lead, Rinn Artificial Intelligence at MTU
• Deputy Theme Lead, Inclusive Language Model & Translation Methods (Rinn AI)
• Principal Investigator, Rinn Artificial Intelligence
• Principal Investigator and MTU Lead, ADAPT Centre
• Founder and Lead, Human-Centred AI Research Group
• Chair, Computer Science Postgraduate Research Board
• Elected Member, MTU Academic Council
• External Expert, European Commission Research Executive Agency
• IEEE Senior Member

Education

• PhD in Computer Science (NLP), Le Mans Université, France, 2014 — Statistical Machine Translation in a Multimodal Context
• MA in Computational Linguistics, Université Grenoble Alpes, France, 2010 — Arabic Speech Translation
• BSc (Hons) in Informatics, Université de Monastir, Tunisia, 2009

Research interests

• Human-Centred AI, Multilingual & Culturally Aware AI, Trustworthy AI, Safety & Governance, Evaluation Science & LLM-as-a-Judge, AI for Healthcare, Biology & Genomics, Responsible Innovation & Commercialisation.

Research centres and funding

Rinn Artificial Intelligence — Taighde Éireann – Research Ireland; Institutional Co-Lead at MTU, Deputy Theme Lead, Principal Investigator. National centre award approximately €121,752,497 (total centre award, not personally allocated).

• Rinn Artificial Intelligence – Research & Innovation in Data Science and AI — Taighde Éireann – Research Ireland; Institutional Co-Lead at MTU; Deputy Theme Lead (Inclusive Language Model & Translation Methods); Principal Investigator; ; 2026–present (Current).
• ADAPT Centre — Research Ireland; MTU Lead Investigator; total €42M (national centre total, not personal); 2021–2027.
• GenDAI — Horizon Europe; Beneficiary; total €1.15M; MTU €220k; 2024–2027.
• ITFLOWS — H2020; Beneficiary; total €4.87M; MTU €528k; 2020–2023.
• WARIFA — H2020; Beneficiary; total €6.72M; MTU €162k; 2021–2024.
• STOP Obesity — H2020; Beneficiary; total €929k; MTU €166k; 2019–2023.
• ELITE-S — H2020 MSCA; Linked Third Party; total €2.27M; MTU €180k; 2018–2024.
• SliceNet — H2020; Beneficiary; total €7.98M; MTU €253k; 2017–2020.

Teaching

• MSc in Artificial Intelligence (MTU) — Co-designed and co-launched; delivers NLP, Machine Learning, Deep Learning (2018–present)
• MSc in Computational Biology (MTU) — Co-led establishment; teaches Machine Learning for Biology (2021–present)
• MSc in Data Analytics (MTU) — Applied Machine Learning (2019–present)
• Executive education — European Central Bank (via Krisolis) — AI, Python, data analytics for ECB staff (2022–present)
• Course website: Machine Learning in Biology (COMP9085) — MSc module · Munster Technological University — https://hafli.github.io/comp9085-ml-biology/
• Course website: Building AI Confidence in the Gaeltacht Workplace (Údarás na Gaeltachta) — Professional training · delivered through Irish — https://hafli.github.io/udaras-ai-course/

Doctoral supervision (completed)

• Dr Praveen Joshi — MTU, 2020–2023; Primary supervisor; Distributed & privacy-preserving deep learning (split/federated learning).
• Dr Séamus Lankford — DCU, 2020–2023; Co-supervisor; Low-resource neural machine translation (Irish).
• Dr Pintu Lohar — DCU, 2016–2020; Co-supervisor; Sentiment-aware machine translation, user-generated content.

Patent

• On-Air Split Federated Learning with Positive Labels — International (PCT) patent application WO/2024/227944, filed 2024-05-03.

Selected publications

• Manuel Frank, Haithem Afli. The Harder Text Embedding Benchmark (HTEB): Beyond One-dimensional Static Robustness. *Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP 2026)*, 2026.
• Haithem Afli, Manuel Frank. The Benchmark Is Not the Construct: Toward Distribution-Based Evaluation in NLP. *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2026*, 2026.
• Shehenaz Hossain, Haithem Afli. CRaFT: An Explanation-Based Framework for Evaluating Cultural Reasoning in Multilingual Language Models. *Proceedings of the Fifteenth Language Resources and Evaluation Conference (LREC 2026)*, 2026.
• Manuel Frank, Haithem Afli. PTEB: Towards Robust Text Embedding Evaluation via Stochastic Paraphrasing at Evaluation Time with LLMs. *Proceedings of the 19th Conference of the European Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics (EACL 2026), Long Papers*, 2026.
• Keren Artiaga, Sabyasachi Kamila, Haithem Afli, Conor Lynch, Mohammed Hasanuzzaman. Rethinking Sign Language Translation: The Impact of Signer Dependence on Model Evaluation. *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2025*, 2025.
• Manuel Frank, Haithem Afli. GASE: Generatively Augmented Sentence Encoding. *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2025*, 2025.
• Thomas Krause, Philippe Tamla, Andrea Leoni, Flavia Monti, Francesca De Luzi, Jamie FitzGerald, Bruno Andrade, Haithem Afli, Massimo Mecella, Paolo Buono, Andrea Molinari, Matthias Hemmje. From Reads to Reports: A Vision for a GFM-Powered Genomic Diagnostic Platform. *IEEE International Conference on Bioinformatics and Biomedicine (BIBM 2025)*, 2025.
• Pournima Sonawane, Haithem Afli. ADAPT–MTU HAI at IWSLT2026: Robust Cascaded Speech Translation for Bhojpuri–Hindi and Irish–English. *Proceedings of the 23rd International Conference on Spoken Language Translation (IWSLT 2026)*, 2026.
• Shehenaz Hossain, Fouad Shammary, Bahaulddin Shammary, Haithem Afli. Enhancing Dialectal Arabic Intent Detection through Cross-Dialect Multilingual Input Augmentation. *Proceedings of the 4th Workshop on Arabic Corpus Linguistics (WACL-4)*, 2025.
• Shehenaz Hossain, Haithem Afli. ADAPT–MTU HAI at QIAS2025: Dual-Expert LLM Fine-Tuning and Constrained Decoding for Arabic Islamic Inheritance Reasoning. *Proceedings of the Third Arabic Natural Language Processing Conference: Shared Tasks*, 2025.
• Shehenaz Hossain, Haithem Afli. ADAPT–MTU HAI at PalmX 2025: Leveraging Full and Parameter-Efficient LLM Fine-Tuning for Arabic Cultural QA. *Proceedings of the Third Arabic Natural Language Processing Conference: Shared Tasks*, 2025.
• Vadim Zadykian, Bruno Andrade, Haithem Afli. Towards Explainable Job Title Matching: Leveraging Semantic Textual Relatedness and Knowledge Graphs. *RecSys in HR'25: 5th Workshop on Recommender Systems for Human Resources (ACM RecSys 2025)*, 2025.

Forthcoming

• Shehenaz Hossain, Houda Bouamor, Haithem Afli. Structural vs Cultural Reasoning: Reliability Limits of LLM-as-a-Judge in Multilingual Evaluation. *AACL 2026* (forthcoming — scheduled to appear in the proceedings), 2026.

Service (selected)

• Chair, CS Postgraduate Research Board, MTU
• Elected Member, MTU Academic Council (2023–)
• Member, MTU AI & Assessment Working Group (2024–)
• Member, MTU EDI Learning Committee (2023–)
• Area Chair — Multilinguality & Machine Translation (incl. Speech-to-Speech), LREC 2026
• PC — ACL (2018, 2019, 2021), NAACL (2021), COLING, LREC (2018, 2020), WANLP (2019–2021)
• General Chair — Political NLP Workshop @ LREC 2022 & LREC-COLING 2024

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